TechEngage: What Gets Engagement

One-page content recommendations | Task ZR-26-00753 | 14 Oct 2026

Data: 546 top tech-news stories from the Hacker News public API (5-13 Oct 2026). Engagement = upvotes + comments; headline stat is the median. Full analysis, dashboard and code: https://github.com/pakmultilinks-dot/techengage-social-engagement-analysis

Finding

- **Short headlines win big.** Posts with headlines of 40 characters or fewer earned a median 207 engagements vs 113 for 61-80 characters (about 1.8x). The drop is monotonic across every length bucket.
- **AI dominates volume; Security and Apple punch above it.** AI was the top topic by count (121 posts) with solid engagement; Security (median 174) and Apple (median 266) earned more per post. Link-style news posts were 91% of all top stories.
- **Timing is directional.** Mid-week posts (Wed-Fri) and 10:00-15:00 UTC (15:00-20:00 PKT) showed the strongest medians, but this comes from an 8-day window, so treat it as a starting hypothesis, not a law.

Three recommendations

1. Cap headlines at 60 characters (aim for 40). Rewrite every headline to its shortest clear form before publishing. This is the single strongest lever in the data and costs nothing to apply.

2. Weight the calendar toward AI, Security, Apple and Open Source news posts. Make AI the daily staple (highest proven volume), and give Security and Apple stories prominent placement and social push (highest per-post engagement). Keep link-style news as the default format.

3. Publish features Tue-Thu, 15:00-20:00 PKT, and measure. Schedule the biggest stories in this window for two weeks, then compare against the baseline. Promote the test in the dashboard so the timing hypothesis gets confirmed or killed with TechEngage's own data.

Limitations: HN's audience skews developer-heavy and US/EU; the sample studies winners only (top/best stories); topics are keyword-classified; weekday/hour patterns are directional. Validate against TechEngage's own analytics before locking the calendar.